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Critique of a Dissertation: Nowhere Man

Skipp, Tracy John

Educational Leadership (2010)

ELC 727 Methods Action Research

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Complete description of the study including the author's line of reasoning

Reading this dissertation was a complete surprise. I chose an Action Research Dissertation that used the autoethnography methodology. In this dissertation, *Nowhere Man: Autoethnographic Reflections on Identity, Family, and Leadership*, Skipp describes the purpose of his self-study to "discover the values and attitudes I model as a leader to support people in doing their best work. Specifically, do I practice leadership Intimacy?"p.viii. One of his goals in this dissertation is to bring the reader into his experience so they can be with him on this journey. In that goal, he succeeded. As I read, I felt as absorbed as when I read a good novel. Chapter One, Context for the Study, begins with a quote from John Lennon and Paul McCartney, which represents why he chose the title Nowhere Man for this work. "Knows not where he's going to; isn't he a bit like you and me?"

Skipp begins by describing his life through his memories, thoughts, and feelings. After a discussion on the history of the University, he describes his upbringing. Being a "military brat," he found solace through his Catholic schooling in the countries where his father was stationed. His writing is deeply personal and arises from one of his five methods of research, Autoethnography as well as a strong desire to heal himself.

The other methods are a 360 assessment, Interviews, Reflective Journaling and Peer Debriefing. He chose autoethnography for this exploration

through his values of Franciscan Roman Catholicism and his life as a senior administrator in a traditional university. To him, those values were in constant conflict. I believed he needed to resolve his daily struggle between “who I see myself to be, and who other students, faculty, and staff perceive me to be (Jourard, 1971)

He suffered every day of his life with pain from rheumatoid arthritis. In the first year of his Doctoral work, his wife who he had been with since he was 15, asked him to “let me go,” I view his choice of using autoethnography, as well as a 360 assessment which included his children, and interviews with his supervisor and peers as a brilliant resolve to his mounting life crises.

And, he certainly achieved the purpose of bringing the reader, me, into his everyday life as I was and am moved to tears, heartbreak, and tenderness as he unswervingly struggles to achieve his goal of “leadership intimacy.” (p.68)

He describes leadership intimacy as authenticity, and authenticity as knowing oneself. He continually identifies with Saint Francis of Assisi, a Catholic saint, medieval monk, and mystic, who also struggled with the question of “who am I” daily.” His deep respect for the values of the Franciscans and his ideas of what a university should be like provides a reflection of his ontology and epistemology.

One of his research questions is “who is training the future generation of leaders? He makes the case that the University is no longer a facility where formal leadership occurs. He believes that leadership intimacy may be a way to offer the leadership mentoring and modeling that he believes is not available presently in universities based on the new economic reality of funding, etc. Operating on a fixed seniority system with a pool of only the most senior staff [faculty] is a very different atmosphere than the corporate fast track model for young executives with obvious, demonstrated talent (Hearn, 2003).

He uses three key concepts to frame his study:

- The philosophy of personalism

- The practice of intimacy
- The role of fatherhood within a family context

Throughout this study, his cognitive dissonance about who he is evident. He works every day as a middle-level administrator in a traditional University and his desire to share the theory of "leadership intimacy," from his personal conflicts. He moves between Marxist and Roman Catholic values in much of his study. The 'Idea of a University' was a village with its priests." Whereas, "the 'Idea of a Modern University' was a town - a one-industry town - with its intellectual oligarchy." (Kerr, 2001p.3) And then he says, "The complex multiversities" have seamlessly morphed into transnational corporations, born of necessity." His choice of becoming a Personalist brings his internal war between his Roman Catholic values and the big business attitude of universities to a halt.

. Personalists maintain that a person, being partly spiritual, is not wholly governed by the laws of physics; and within certain limits, can exercise free will and as such are not completely predictable.

. Personalists accept axiology, or value-theory and disagree with the logical positivists (influenced by science) affirming the absolute value of each person. (Gregg, 1999, pp. 167-168)

His belief of how to be a leader, father, ex-husband, and administrator are reflected in the following quote: "It is through our responses to other persons that we become persons. It is others who challenge, enlighten and enrich us. There is no such thing as an isolated individual Reality is the lived relation. Through sharing in the giving and receiving of mutual being the, "I" becomes real." (Oldham, 1958)

Literature Search and Review

His Literature Review was motivated by a crisis as to whether he was

sufficiently prepared (p. 27) to lead. I find throughout the dissertation, a continuing attempt to prove he is o.k. as a person. He shares many stories about the people he works. The most poignant is a confrontation he has with his supervisor where she tells him because he is not a faculty member, he is like the water boy on the team. "she was also prone to fits of rage." (p.28)

With a dearth of literature on Intimacy Leadership. He explored,

- Visionary Leadership
- Collaborative Leadership
- Reflective Leadership
- Communicative Leadership
- Relational Leadership

After a thorough review of these leadership methodologies, he said, "none of them frame my professional experience or leadership practice (Raelin, 2003). Perhaps this is because traditional leadership is often studied in a business model." Rather, he approached his most coveted mentor, Brother Richard, a Franciscan monk that lived a few blocks away and tended the garden in the church, and spoke to him of what he learned in his literature search,

"I guess I would see leadership in three parts," I explained. "The first part is intimacy with self; you must disclose self to authentically know yourself, and you must know yourself to get to know others. The second part is intimacy with others, from a personalist perspective or philosophy, it relies on relationships to exist. The third part is developmental intimacy; you must give others a safe place to grow and nurture those relationships. We need those relationships to exist. It is a circular flow, a process that we continually go through life."(p.48)

Research Methods

Reflexive poetics: This comes from two similar strategies, reflexive ethnography (Ellis & Bochner, 1996) and anthropological poetics (Brady 1991). Uses internal dialogue, conversations with self to evoke strong feelings in the reader. Visual form of evocative narrative (Bochner & Ellis 1997)

Autoethnography: the Personal style of writing known as narrative inquiry, (Bochner, Ellis, Tillman-Healy, 1997, 1998) "A stream of consciousness like watching a film. An intensely personal format for social science that invites the reader into the mind and thoughts of the researcher." (p.52, 3) Ellis (2004) describes this experience as a collaborative journal between the author and the reader. Krizek (1998) says "in short, we often render our research reports devoid of human emotion and self-reflection. As ethnographers, we experience life, but we write science.' (p.93) Autoethnography, the way Skipp describes it has its roots in phenomenology.

Qualitative research, as a descriptive term, covering several forms of inquiry studying in a social context (Merriam, 1998) with an emphasis on cultural setting.

Data Collection

This section of the critique is the most difficult for me to decipher He believed he could do this study on his own. (Feldman (2003) created four criteria which data collection could take place in autoethnography:

1. Clarity of how data collection will occur
2. Clear descriptions of how to construct the representation from the data. What were the specifics
3. Extend triangulation beyond multiple sources of data to include explorations of various ways to represent the same self-study

4. Provide evidence that the research changed the subject and summarized its value to the profession (27-28)

Although he used a peer debriefer for various discussions about his leadership, I couldn't see any value the in these discussions for middle level administrator/leaders in a most University settings. I certainly saw the value to him personally.

The questions he asked were:

- What values do I lead by?
- What attitudes and practices do I model as a leader:
- Specifically, do I practice leadership intimacy?
- Meaning, what is the appropriate role of interpersonal relationships in developing leaders?

Eight Interviews were recorded and transcribed. A colleague administered the interviews to his children and seven former peers using vignettes and transcribing them. He used the methodology of idea units, and joint-probability of agreement model (Uebersax,)1987, this method is the least complex and “for this reason, the least robust.” (p.90)

The three values that were measured in idea units were: Metanoia, know yourself, Humility, focus on others and Solitude, safe harbor. He scored highest in Solitude, then Humility and then Metanoia. This meant to him that his self-evaluation and the 360 data was congruent using his data collection methods.

I became and still am confused while reading the results and indications of this study. I was unable to find conclusions that were not contradictory. His ideas that were measured, were not the ones I thought he was looking at through the lens of “leadership intimacy,” which was authenticity. The three leadership values that were measured came from the Roman Catholic values he so wanted to instill in his working life at the University.

I believe Tracy John Skipp made a valuable contribution to the literature of Autoethnography. I felt connected through his narrative and as I said earlier was moved from time to time. The other methodologies he used, such as vignettes, and the eight interviews were presented in ways that were both unclear and tedious to me. I was unable to move from the personal aspect, which accomplished his stated goal of taking the reader with him, and the impersonal, universal, research methodology used in the dissertation.

Dissertation

NOWHERE MAN:
AUTOETHNOGRAPHIC REFLECTIONS ON
IDENTITY, FAMILY, AND LEADERSHIP
BY TRACY JOHN SKIPP

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